Shareholders and Directors

What was the response to the initial public offering and who invested in SSNCo?

We do not have actual numbers, but the response was certainly encouraging. The press was agog with enthusiastic letters. Correspondents from various parts of the presidency, and even outside, commended the effort and proffered advice. One ‘Matha Magan’ (‘[Bharat] Mother’s Son’), writing from Colombo, apart from expressing dissatisfaction with Colombo traders for not being sufficiently patriotic, was especially harsh on the Vellala merchants for their lukewarm response. Calling for public meetings to sensitize the people, he urged the formation of committees consisting of (traditional merchant communities with overseas business connections such as) the Nattukkottai Chettiars, and the (Muslim) Marakayars of Karaikal and Nagapattinam. Volunteers needed to be sent out to canvass for shares. Referring to the raising of a National Fund in Madras City on the occasion of Deepavali, he asked why similar efforts were not afoot in Tuticorin and Colombo. He also called upon Muslims and Christians to emulate this example and collect funds on their holy days.[48] Throughout its brief life, SSNCo was never short of advice on how to raise capital and conduct its business. Though well-meaning, the practical value of such advice was moot.

As the promoters of the company, the traders and businessmen of Tuticorin were naturally the prime investors. While all of them were businessmen, none had any experience as such of shipping management.[49] The composition of the management of the company in the first prospectus confirms S.D. Krishna Aiyangar’s later evidence to the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee that the company germinated when the insulted Tuticorin traders sought the help of local legal professionals to establish a shipping enterprise of their own.[50] The first cohort of the fifteen directors were all described as Tuticorin merchants, which perhaps explains the motivated European accusation that ‘Indian inexperience in the shipping trade and mismanagement on the part of the promoters’ was the cause of the